

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in the letters to the editor section of a newspaper in Hong Kong:

No Attendance No Problem

I support the Hong Kong Baptist University's (HKBU) recent decision to relax attendance requirements for all its students. In the past, students skipping more than 30 per cent of classes would fail a course automatically. Under the new policy, they can still pass with less-than-perfect attendance records.

I feel this new policy may improve the overall quality of teaching and stimulate innovation among teaching staff at the university.

University students are young adults who should learn to make responsible decisions on how to spend their time. If they find a better way to study course materials than attending lectures, the university should respect their choices.

Also, under the new policy, all university teachers must rethink how to attract students with more effective teaching, as their attendance is no longer guaranteed.

As a lecturer at the university myself, I have created a series of video lectures students will watch in advance. They can learn the basic concepts and techniques at their own pace through the videos and assigned reading. They can then discuss the materials and receive my feedback on their thinking during classes. I have also created WhatsApp groups for my students to discuss course materials outside the classrooms.

With the new attendance policy, Baptist University is well positioned to provide more resources allowing students to access course materials in videos, to study anywhere using their mobile devices and to juggle different commitments in more flexible schedules.

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Your careers advisor has asked you to discuss attendance policies in education. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages and disadvantages of HKBU's attendance policy
- whether you think the policy will be successful
- whether it could be applied to secondary schools
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like learning online?
2. Is it important for students to go to all classes?
3. How would parents feel about a relaxed attendance policy?
4. Should students who don't go to class still pass the course?
5. Are video lessons the same as face-to-face lessons?
6. Why is face-to-face teaching sometimes helpful?
7. Are students mature enough to decide if they need to go to class?
8. Is attendance more important in some classes than others?